total income of ₹1,027.34 crore, while the Congress declared an income of 199.15 crore.[26] The gaps in online spends between the two parties, in that sense, is reflective of the relative size of their political war chests offline.

Furthermore, the volume of declared political advertising on digital platforms is extremely low when compared to total declared campaign expenditure. The Congress declared ₹820 crore to the ECI as campaign expenditure in 2019. The BJP declared over ₹1,264 crore as its campaign spending in 2019 to the ECI, in comparison to ₹714 crore it declared as election expenditure in 2014.[27]

Moreover, there are serious definitional issues on what counts as political advertising. Most political spending on digital platforms is not done directly by the parties themselves but by affiliates or sympathetic groups that are technically separate. This allows for plausible deniability. Clearly, political parties are spending significantly larger amounts on digital platforms—for digital messaging, digital war rooms and troll armies—than is declared. What gets reported and pre-certified as political advertising is only a small fraction of the larger political mobilisation activities. For example, a divisive but anonymous WhatsApp or ShareChat forward depicting a particular religious community adversely may carry political weight as a signalling device to polarise the public. Such a forward is undoubtedly political in nature, but will never be classified as political advertising. It is also almost impossible to trace the origins of such messages.

Even the certified spending figures on Big Tech platforms can be deceptive, with much of the advertising money being spent by groups that support the party from outside. Consider Facebook: while the BJP was the highest declared spender among political parties in February-March 2019, seven of the top ten spenders on its advertisers' list for this period were entities sympathetic to the party. These ranged from pages like 'My First Vote for Modi', 'Bharat ke Mann ki Baat' and 'Nation with NaMo'.

By mid-2020, serious questions began to be raised about the neutrality of tech platforms and their alleged political biases. The *Wall Street Journal* (*WSJ*) broke a story accusing Facebook's then